

The Dependency Nobody Decided

Edition 1 in a series on UK procurement from the United States, scoped to the instruments and levers rather than to any single programme or department.

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Mirams, on how the UK buys from the United States ·

Horizon: to 2030

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What you will learn

1. Why Britain's position on American supply was settled without anyone having to decide it
2. Where the dependency is hardest to reverse, and why that part was never debated
3. What other governments now write into contracts that Britain writes into strategy documents

Key takeaways

1. The UK left the European financing instrument on a value for money test and published no assessment of what that locks in
2. The cloud estate was bought through framework extension, and the award is the last point at which conditions can attach
3. Powers of exclusion and debarment have been live since February 2025 and the published list is blank

Why This Matters Now

Britain's reliance on American suppliers is usually discussed as a question about the future. Will the United States stay reliable? The evidence of the last eighteen months suggests a different question is overdue. The direction has already been set, by a series of separate decisions none of which announced itself as a choice about dependency.

The UK left the European defence financing instrument, deepened the American export-control arrangement, and consolidated its cloud buying into a single larger agreement. Each was defensible on its own terms. Together they amount to a settled position that no document states, no metric tracks and no minister has been asked to defend as a whole.

The one thing to take into the next meeting: the problem is not that Britain chose dependence, it is that nobody had to argue for it, so there is no statement of how much would be too much.

Executive Synthesis

Which document states how much dependence on a single foreign supplier this country is willing to carry, and who signed it?

The defence industrial strategy narrows sovereignty to a short list of protected capabilities and accepts allied supply elsewhere, the procurement policy statement contains no supplier origin requirement at all, and the national security debarment list has been open since February 2025 with nothing on it.

Take the eighteen months in order. In May 2025 the UK and the EU signed a Security and Defence Partnership that commits both sides to regular exchanges on defence industry and defers every industrial and procurement question to a later negotiation ([the Security and Defence Partnership](#), May 2025). In June the Strategic Defence Review observed that the United States is clear the security of Europe is no longer its primary focus, and answered with NATO First ([the Strategic Defence Review](#), Jun 2025). In September the Defence Industrial Strategy reserved full or majority UK industrial capability for a short list, the nuclear deterrent, submarines and cryptography, and accepted allied supply elsewhere, with an offset policy as the compensating mechanism ([CP 1388](#), Sep 2025). In December the negotiation on joining the European financing instrument ended without agreement ([the Paymaster General](#), Dec 2025), and the Paymaster General told the Commons he had chosen not to participate because it did not represent value for money ([Hansard](#), Dec 2025). Thirteen days later the American export-control exemption took effect ([the US Department of State](#), Dec 2025).

Each of those is defensible. What none of them does is state a position on dependence. The gap shows most clearly in what the December decision actually cost. Under third country terms UK firms may supply up to 35% of the content of a SAFE contract ([the Paymaster General](#), Dec 2025), which sounds like access until you read why that number exists: the regulation requires at least 65% of component value to come from eligible European sources ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025). The French Senate, examining the same instrument, records that the United States supplied 64% of the arms imported by European NATO states between 2020 and 2024 and argues that European preference has to be hardened into a condition of European money or Europeans remain subcontractors ([the French Senate](#), Dec 2025). Britain is not inside that argument. It is the third country the rule is drawn against.

Meanwhile the dependency that would be hardest to unwind is not in defence at all. UK cloud spending reached 10.5 billion pounds in 2024, growing by nearly 30% a year, with two American firms holding between 60% and 80% of the market ([POSTnote 777](#), Aug 2026). Government spends at least 14 billion pounds a year on digital, of which 9 billion ran through central Crown Commercial Service agreements ([the National Audit Office](#), Jan 2025), and the Public Accounts Committee found the Government Commercial Function had fifteen people managing the nineteen largest technology suppliers ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Jun 2025). None of that was a strategic decision about the United States. It was routine central buying, extended and enlarged: G-Cloud 14 was extended by 1.65 billion pounds and six months, after a mid-contract uplift of 89% to one hyperscaler deal ([DatacenterDynamics](#), Jul 2025), and its successor was put to market at 14 billion pounds ([the tender notice](#), Oct 2025).

The problem is not that Britain chose dependence. It is that nobody had to argue for it, so there is no statement of how much would be too much.

What makes this the moment to say so is that other governments have stopped treating supply reliability as a diplomatic matter and started writing it into instruments. The European regulation requires contractors to be able to decide, without restrictions imposed by third countries, on the design of what is procured, including the legal authority to remove components subject to such restrictions ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025). That is reliability as an engineering specification. France went further on the civil side: a decree made in April 2026 requires state bodies processing particularly sensitive data on private cloud to use a service holding the national security agency's qualification, and to be protected against access by third-country authorities

([the French finance ministry](#), Apr 2026). The interministerial digital directorate has told every ministry to produce a dependency reduction plan by autumn in French, “L'État ne peut plus se contenter de constater sa dépendance, il doit en sortir”, which reads in English as “The State can no longer be content to observe its dependency, it must exit it” ([the French interministerial digital directorate](#), Apr 2026). The European Commission has since proposed writing a European Preference chapter into the base procurement regulation, and is explicit that this sits inside the Government Procurement Agreement rather than against it ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026).

Set the British instruments beside those. The National Procurement Policy Statement, which contracting authorities must have regard to, contains no supplier origin requirement and handles security as a supply chain control standard ([the National Procurement Policy Statement](#), Feb 2025). The June 2026 policy note on protecting national security tells buyers they may “Deploy the national security exemption in the Procurement Act 2023 where appropriate and justified in a relevant procurement” ([PPN 025](#), Jun 2026), names four critical sectors, shipbuilding, steel, artificial intelligence and energy infrastructure, and does not name cloud or digital infrastructure at all. The statutory machinery exists: a National Security Unit for Procurement, powers of exclusion, termination and debarment, live since February 2025. The published debarment list is blank ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025). This is not an argument that Britain should copy France. It is an observation that Britain has chosen discretion, and discretion leaves no record of a decision.

The final piece is that the American arrangement Britain did deepen is narrower than it reads. The export-control exemption removes licensing for authorised users, and over 700 entities have been authorised, but the State Department's own assessment is that “it monitored licensing requests for Australia or the United Kingdom against the ETL over a three-month period and assesses approximately 18% of such licensing requests would not be eligible for transfer under the exemption because of the ETL” ([the US Department of State](#), Dec 2025). Independent analysis of the reforms reached the same structural conclusion before the rule was final, that this is a free trade zone defined by country and not by technology, so the carve-outs fall on exactly the advanced work the arrangement exists to share ([the United States Studies Centre](#), Aug 2024). On the flagship programme, the Public Accounts Committee records a formal UK policy requirement of freedom of action alongside a weapons integration path the UK cannot influence ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Oct 2025), while the American audit office reports that upgrade descope, more than 6 billion dollars over and five years late ([the Government Accountability Office](#), Sep 2025).

Where this analysis could be wrong

The value for money case may simply be right. Nothing in this evidence shows what the European instrument would have cost the UK to join, because that number is not public. A government that declined an expensive loan facility offering uncertain industrial return made a defensible call, and the Opposition's criticism of it was political rather than analytical. The narrower claim here is that the decision was justified on a transactional test, in a sentence about value for money, and that no assessment was published weighing it against the dependency position it locks in. That is a gap in the record, not proof of a wrong answer.

The American relationship is not only a liability, and the same committee that warned about it said so. The Lords committee recommending a twin-track hedge also welcomed the export-control exemptions as removing a significant regulatory barrier, and separately judged that Britain's own failure to meet initial order commitments has dented its reputation as a partner ([the House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee](#), Apr 2026). Dependence runs in both directions and the United States is not the only party whose reliability is in question. Any policy built on the assumption that Britain is the aggrieved side will be badly calibrated.

The legal reading here is one reading. The non-discrimination duty owed to treaty state suppliers under the Procurement Act would constrain a European preference rule ([Procurement Act guidance](#), Sep 2024), but the European Commission's own proposal shows that a party to the same trade agreement believes preference can be designed within it ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026). Whether the UK could do likewise is a question for law officers rather than for this briefing, and it is raised as a question rather than settled. One further caveat on evidence: two figures in the framework theme, the single-bidder award value and the mid-contract uplift, rest on trade press because the official tender records could not be retrieved, and the appendix says so.

The decisions that cannot be deferred this cycle

1. **Ask for the number that does not exist.** No published measure states what share of defence or digital procurement flows to US-controlled suppliers, so no one can say whether the position is getting better or worse.

2. **Treat the blank debarment list as a finding, not an absence.** Powers of exclusion and debarment have been live since February 2025 and have produced nothing on the published list, which is either evidence that no supplier warrants it or evidence that the lever is unusable.
3. **Decide whether reliability is a specification or a relationship.** Europe has begun writing design authority and third-country access protection into binding rules, and Britain has not, which is a choice worth making deliberately rather than by default.
4. **Put cloud inside the national security conversation.** The June policy note names shipbuilding, steel, artificial intelligence and energy infrastructure as critical sectors, and omits the cloud estate that carries most of government's data.

Each is developed below, with a decision posture, in the four Strategic Implications.

Audience Snapshots

Four lenses on the same evidence base. Each card surfaces the one question this cycle puts to that reader.

INSTRUMENTS AND LEVERS

The powers exist and the published record shows them unused

The shift: The procurement policy statement carries no supplier origin requirement ([the National Procurement Policy Statement](#), Feb 2025), the national security policy note is permissive and omits cloud ([PPN 025](#), Jun 2026), and the debarment list has been open since February 2025 with nothing published on it ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025).

The question to brief: If we wanted to act on supplier origin tomorrow, which existing power would we use, and what has stopped anyone using it so far?

CONCENTRATION AND MARKETS

The deepest dependency was bought through administrative extension rather than decisions

The shift: Government digital spend runs to at least 14 billion pounds a year with 9 billion through central frameworks ([the National Audit Office](#), Jan 2025), two American firms hold 60% to 80% of UK cloud ([POSTnote 777](#), Aug 2026), and the regulator declined to open a market status investigation into the largest cloud provider ([the Competition and Markets Authority](#), Mar 2026).

The question to brief: Which of our current commitments renew without a fresh competition, and when is the next point at which anything can actually change?

ALLIANCE AND EXPORT CONTROL

The arrangement Britain deepened is bounded by a list the United States controls

The shift: The exemption is assessed to leave roughly a fifth of licence requests ineligible ([the US Department of State](#), Dec 2025), independent analysis calls it a zone defined by country rather than technology ([the United States Studies Centre](#), Aug 2024), and the flagship programme's upgrade path is descoped and five years late ([the Government Accountability Office](#), Sep 2025).

The question to brief: On which specific capabilities does the exemption not reach, and what is the plan for those?

EVIDENCE AND OVERSIGHT

Nobody publishes the measure that would let anyone judge this

The shift: Official statistics record 623 million pounds of Foreign Military Sales payments and separate payments to the US Government and Treasury, without any headline figure for total spend with US suppliers ([MOD official statistics](#), Sep 2025), while the audit office finds procurement leadership unaligned ([the National Audit Office](#), Jan 2025).

The question to brief: What would a published dependency measure have to contain to be worth having, and who would own it?

Themes

The cycle's signals are organised into four themes, ranked by impact on near-term decisions.

Immediate: changes the near-term plan, the structure or the proposition. **Near-Term:** changes position over the next twelve months. **Longer-Range:** a multi-year factor to track and revisit each cycle.

1. Britain has already chosen, and did not call it a choice

IMMEDIATE

Between May 2025 and September 2026 the United Kingdom took a series of decisions that together settle its supply relationship with the United States for the rest of the decade. It signed a European security partnership that defers industrial questions ([the Security and Defence Partnership](#), May 2025), published a defence review organised around NATO First ([the Strategic Defence Review](#), Jun 2025), published an industrial strategy narrowing sovereign capability to a protected list ([CP 1388](#), Sep 2025), walked away from the European financing instrument ([the Paymaster General](#), Dec 2025), and let the American export-control exemption come into force ([the US Department of State](#), Dec 2025). No single one of those was framed as a decision about dependence. Together they are one.

Sixteen months in which the question was answered without being asked

May 2025	●	Security and Defence Partnership signed, industry questions deferred
May 2025	●	European regulation sets a 65% European content rule and design authority
Sep 2025	●	Defence Industrial Strategy narrows sovereignty to a short protected list
Oct 2025	●	Successor cloud agreement put to market at 14 billion pounds
Dec 2025	●	Talks on joining the European instrument end without agreement
Dec 2025	●	American export-control exemption takes effect, inside an excluded list
Apr 2026	●	France makes a cloud sovereignty qualification a legal condition
Jun 2026	●	UK policy note tells buyers they may use the security exemption
Sep 2026	●	European Commission proposes a preference chapter in procurement law

The red marker is the only entry that was a decision not to do something. Navy markers are British decisions, grey are decisions taken elsewhere that bear on British choices. None of the nine was presented as a judgement

- The Paymaster General told the Commons he chose not to participate in the European instrument because it did not represent value for money ([Hansard](#), Dec 2025). That is the whole of the published reasoning, and no assessment weighing it against the resulting supply position has been laid.
- Third country access lets UK firms supply up to 35% of the content of a contract under that instrument ([the Paymaster General](#), Dec 2025). The figure is the residue of the regulation's requirement that at least 65% of component value come from eligible European sources ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025).
- The Security and Defence Partnership contains no reference to procurement, industrial capability, programmes or financial contribution, and one reference to industry ([the Security and Defence Partnership](#), May 2025). That absence was checked against the text rather than inferred.
- The Defence Industrial Strategy reserves full or majority UK capability for the nuclear deterrent, submarines and cryptography, accepts allied supply for everything else, and offers an offset policy as the compensating mechanism ([CP 1388](#), Sep 2025).
- Official statistics record 623 million pounds of Foreign Military Sales payments to the US Government in 2024-25, plus 1,202 million pounds to the US Government and 372 million to the US Treasury, described as predominantly F-35 and Trident ([MOD official statistics](#), Sep 2025). There is no published headline figure for total UK spend with US-based suppliers.

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The instrument Britain declined is now the venue for the argument it is not in.** The French Senate, examining the same regulation, records that the United States supplied 64% of arms imported by European NATO states between 2020 and 2024, and argues European preference must be hardened into a condition of European money ([the French Senate](#), Dec 2025). That debate will set the terms on which British firms sell into Europe, and Britain is outside it as the third country the rule is drawn against.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The trade arrangement underneath all this is explicitly not binding.** Parliament's own research service describes the Economic Prosperity Deal as legally non-binding and only partially implemented, with the metals exemption contingent on the progress of negotiations ([the House of Commons Library](#), Apr 2026). A supply relationship resting on a conditional arrangement is a different thing from one resting on a treaty.

Counter-argument

The strongest objection is that this reads a pattern into decisions that were each taken on their merits by different departments over sixteen months, which is how government works and is not evidence of drift. It is also possible the European instrument genuinely was poor value, and nothing here shows otherwise, because the price was never published. The claim made is narrower than a charge of negligence: it is that no instrument states an acceptable degree of dependence, no measure tracks it, and therefore no one is in a position to say whether the accumulated position is the one they would have chosen. The thesis weakens the moment any department publishes a dependency assessment covering more than one programme.

Decision link: Draws on SI 1

2. The dependency that is load bearing was bought through frameworks

IMMEDIATE

The dependency most discussed is in defence. The dependency hardest to reverse is in the cloud estate, and it was never decided at all. It was bought through central buying agreements, extended administratively and enlarged mid-contract, in a market where two American firms hold most of the supply. This is where an adviser looking for the real exposure should look, because it is the part with the least deliberation behind it and the most switching cost in front of it.

One buying channel, enlarged twice, with no fresh decision point

G-Cloud 14 as awarded
original agreement value

 7.5 billion pounds

G-Cloud 14 extension
six further months, July 2025

 1.65 billion pounds added

G-Cloud 15 to market
replacing three vehicles, Oct 2025

 14 billion pounds

Bars are drawn to the stated values. The extension bar is the amount added, not a new total. Between the first and last of these, one hyperscaler hosting deal was also uplifted by 89% mid-contract. The framework values are what the channel may carry, not what has been spent through it.

- UK cloud spending reached 10.5 billion pounds in 2024 after growing nearly 30% a year since 2020, with Amazon Web Services and Microsoft holding between 60% and 80% of the market ([POSTnote 777](#), Aug 2026).
- Government spends at least 14 billion pounds a year on digital programmes and technology, of which 9 billion ran through central Crown Commercial Service agreements in 2022-23, and three providers hold over 60% of global cloud provision ([the National Audit Office](#), Jan 2025).
- The Public Accounts Committee found the approach to buying cloud fragmented and not right, and recorded fifteen officials dedicated to managing the nineteen largest technology suppliers ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Jun 2025).
- The channel itself compounds. G-Cloud 14 was extended by six months and 1.65 billion pounds, following a mid-contract uplift of 89% to one hyperscaler hosting deal ([DatacenterDynamics](#), Jul 2025), and its successor went to market consolidating three vehicles at a value of 14 billion pounds ([the tender notice](#), Oct 2025).
- The competition regulator decided in March 2026 to open a market status investigation into one firm's business software and not into the largest cloud provider, accepting voluntary commitments on egress fees and interoperability instead ([the Competition and Markets Authority](#), Mar 2026). No enforceable cloud remedy exists.

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The government's own answer is a demand signal, not a rule.** The 2026 cloud challenge book tells the market that single in-country regions are not sufficient, that public cloud as implemented today struggles against the most capable adversaries, and that approaches must avoid structural lock-in ([the Cloud Challenge Book](#), Jul 2026). It is an invitation to suppliers and it obliges no department to do anything.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The legal exposure is real and the traffic runs the other way.** American law can compel US providers to hand over data held in their UK data centres ([the House of Commons Library](#), Mar 2026). But Parliament's science office records that the UK used the bilateral data access agreement 20,142 times between 2022 and 2024 against 63 US uses ([POSTnote 777](#), Aug 2026). The dependency is genuine; the picture of a one-directional American reach into British data is not.

Counter-argument

It is fair to answer that hyperscale cloud is simply better, that no British or European provider offers the same capability at the same price, and that concentration is the normal shape of a market with these economics. The regulator, having looked, accepted commitments rather than imposing remedies, which is a considered judgement by the body best placed to make it. The argument here is not that the buying was wrong. It is that a position of this size was reached without anyone being required to state what degree of concentration was acceptable, and that administrative extension is a mechanism for compounding commitments without a decision point. The thesis weakens if the successor award publishes concentration limits or exit terms.

Decision link: Draws on SI 2

3. Reliability is becoming a specification rather than a diplomatic question

NEAR-TERM

The most consequential shift in this evidence base is not about American behaviour. It is that other governments have stopped treating supplier reliability as something to be managed through relationships and started writing it into rules, contracts and designs. Once reliability is a specification, a country that treats it as a relationship is not making a different choice. It is failing to make one.

- The European regulation requires contractors to be able to decide, without restrictions imposed by third countries or third-country entities, on the definition and evolution of the design of what is procured, including the legal authority to substitute or remove restricted components

([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025). Reliability is written as design authority.

- The American exemption is bounded by a list. The State Department assesses that “it monitored licensing requests for Australia or the United Kingdom against the ETL over a three-month period and assesses approximately 18% of such licensing requests would not be eligible for transfer under the exemption because of the ETL” ([the US Department of State](#), Dec 2025), and over 700 Australian and British entities have become authorised users.
- Independent analysis before the rule was final concluded the reforms would exempt 70% to 80% of trilateral trade while producing a zone defined by country rather than technology, so the carve-outs fall on the advanced work the arrangement exists to share ([the United States Studies Centre](#), Aug 2024).
- On the flagship programme the Public Accounts Committee records a formal UK requirement of freedom of action alongside weapons integration dependent on software the UK cannot influence ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Oct 2025), while the American audit office reports that upgrade descope, over 6 billion dollars above estimate and at least five years late ([the Government Accountability Office](#), Sep 2025).
- A French government body reports that a single controlled component can contaminate an entire system and that restrictions may follow for commercial as well as strategic reasons, and records that only 52% of European NATO contracts between February 2022 and September 2024 concerned European systems ([the Haut-commissariat à la Stratégie et au Plan](#), Jun 2026).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **One allied buyer has already shown what treating this as a contract looks like.** Told to expect a Patriot delivery delay of five to seven years, Switzerland suspended payments and went back to the market: in German, “Aufgrund dieser Unsicherheiten hält die Schweiz an der Sistierung der Zahlungen an die US-Regierung für Patriot fest”, which reads in English as “Because of these uncertainties Switzerland is maintaining its suspension of payments to the US Government for Patriot” ([the Swiss defence department](#), May 2026), with responses sought from five further suppliers offering German, French, Israeli and South Korean systems. Switzerland is neither an EU nor a NATO member, so the case does not transfer cleanly, but the behaviour is the point.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Britain's own committee has already recommended the hedge.** The Lords committee recommends engaging with the United States on shared interests while hedging against US volatility through increased sovereign capability and cooperation with European allies ([the House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee](#), Apr 2026). The recommendation exists. What does not exist is an instrument that would carry it.

Counter-argument

The honest counter is that specification is cheap and capability is not. A design authority clause does not build an alternative engine, radar or satellite constellation, and a country that writes stringent third-country conditions into its rules may simply find that nothing compliant exists at an affordable price. The same Lords committee that recommended hedging welcomed the export-control exemption as removing a significant regulatory barrier ([the House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee](#), Apr 2026), which is the honest recognition that access to American technology is worth something. The claim is not that Britain should adopt European-style conditions. It is that reliability is now being priced and contracted for elsewhere, and that a country with no position on it will be a price taker.

Decision link: Draws on SI 3

4. Europe legislates sovereignty, Britain leaves it to the buyer

NEAR-TERM

The clearest contrast in this cycle is institutional rather than political. Continental governments are converting sovereignty preferences into binding requirements: certification thresholds, origin tests, mandated reduction plans. Britain has the machinery to do something similar and has chosen instead to empower individual buyers to exercise judgement. That is a legitimate choice. Its consequence is that nothing is recorded, nothing accumulates and no one can be asked to account for the aggregate.

- A French decree made in April 2026 requires state bodies processing particularly sensitive data on private cloud to use a service holding the national security agency's qualification or an equivalent European certification, and to be protected against access by third-country public authorities ([the French finance ministry](#), Apr 2026). It is a legal precondition of the contract rather than a buyer's judgement.
- The interministerial digital directorate requires every ministry and its operators to produce a dependency reduction plan by autumn 2026 covering workstations, collaborative tools, antivirus, artificial intelligence, databases, virtualisation and network equipment ([the French interministerial digital directorate](#), Apr 2026).
- The European cloud framework grades sovereignty into four assurance levels, reaching providers owned and controlled from the EU at level three and full software supply chain control with no third-country interference at level four ([the European Commission](#), Jun 2026).
- In September 2026 the Commission proposed replacing the procurement directives with a single regulation carrying a European Preference chapter, and stated repeatedly that the mechanism operates within the Government Procurement Agreement ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026).

- The British statutory statement that authorities must have regard to contains no supplier origin requirement, treating security as a supply chain control standard ([the National Procurement Policy Statement](#), Feb 2025), and the June 2026 policy note is permissive, naming shipbuilding, steel, artificial intelligence and energy infrastructure as critical sectors while omitting cloud ([PPN 025](#), Jun 2026).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The lever has been available for nineteen months and the list is empty.** The National Security Unit for Procurement has overseen powers of exclusion, termination and debarment since February 2025, exclusion on national security grounds requires ministerial agreement, and the published debarment list remains blank ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025). That is either a finding about suppliers or a finding about the instrument, and which it is has not been established.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Germany shows there is a third option, and how slow it is.** The federal government reports 8,756 openDesk licences in the federal administration and that of 577 software development contracts awarded in 2025, 109 were commissioned as open source and only 42 published openly ([the German federal government](#), Apr 2026). Supply-side substitution avoids the legal difficulty of an origin rule and, on the government's own figures, moves slowly.

Counter-argument

The serious objection is legal rather than political. The Procurement Act owes a non-discrimination duty to suppliers of every state with which the UK has a relevant agreement, so a European preference rule could not simply be announced ([Procurement Act guidance](#), Sep 2024). Discretion may therefore be less a philosophy than a constraint. Against that, the European Commission has just proposed preference inside the base procurement statute while insisting it is compatible with the same international agreement ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026), which suggests the constraint shapes the design rather than forbidding it. The thesis weakens if law officers publish advice that the UK's commitments are materially narrower than the EU's.

Decision link: Draws on SI 4

Strategic Implications

Four implications, each tied to a theme and each carrying a posture. Decide means the decision is live now and deferring it is itself a choice. Prepare means the work has to start now for a decision that lands later. Monitor means the evidence does not yet support acting, and says what would change that.

SI 1: Commission the dependency measure that does not exist

The official statistics record Foreign Military Sales payments and collaborative programme payments as accounting lines, with no headline figure for total spend with US-controlled suppliers ([MOD official statistics](#), Sep 2025), and the position across digital is assembled from an audit report and two library briefings rather than from any single published measure ([the National Audit Office](#), Jan 2025). Without a number there is no trend, and without a trend every individual procurement decision looks locally reasonable. This is the cheapest of the four recommendations and the one everything else depends on.

Action: Specify what a published dependency measure would contain: share of spend by ultimate supplier control rather than contracting entity, coverage of defence and digital together, and treatment of framework call-offs. Then identify who could be asked to own it, whether the audit office, the Cabinet Office or a select committee, and ask the question in a form that produces a dated answer.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 1

SI 2: Attach conditions at the award, because there is no later moment

The successor cloud agreement went to market at 14 billion pounds, consolidating three vehicles ([the tender notice](#), Oct 2025), after its predecessor grew by administrative extension and a mid-contract uplift of 89% to one hosting deal ([DatacenterDynamics](#), Jul 2025). The regulator has declined to impose cloud remedies and accepted voluntary commitments ([the Competition and Markets Authority](#), Mar 2026). Once departments migrate, switching is expensive, complex and disruptive on the Committee's own evidence ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Jun 2025). The award is the decision point, and there is not another one.

Action: Press for the award to carry things a later negotiation cannot recover: published exit and data egress terms, a concentration measure reported annually, and a standing requirement that call-offs above a threshold record why an alternative was not viable. None of that requires an origin rule or new legislation.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 2

SI 3: Decide whether the UK will specify reliability or keep negotiating it

The European instrument requires design authority free of third-country restriction as a condition of funding ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025), France has made a certification a legal precondition for sensitive data ([the French finance ministry](#), Apr 2026), and one allied buyer has already suspended payments and reopened a competition when an American delivery date slipped ([the Swiss defence department](#), May 2026). Britain has a formal requirement of freedom of action on its flagship programme and an upgrade path it cannot influence ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Oct 2025). The gap between those two facts is the policy question.

Action: Draft, as a test, the clause the UK would use if it decided reliability were a specification: what design authority would mean in a British contract, which capabilities it would apply to, and what it would cost in supplier choice. The point of drafting it is to find out whether the reason Britain has not done this is principle, law or capability, because the answer determines everything downstream.

PREPARE

Draws on Theme 3

SI 4: Treat the empty debarment list as the test of whether discretion works

The powers exist. Exclusion, termination and debarment have been available since February 2025 through a dedicated unit, exclusion on national security grounds requires ministerial agreement, and the published list is blank ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025). The June 2026 policy note is permissive and omits cloud from its critical sectors ([PPN 025](#), Jun 2026), and the statutory statement carries no origin requirement ([the National Procurement Policy Statement](#), Feb 2025). Either no supplier has warranted action, which would be worth knowing, or the lever is not usable, which would be worth knowing sooner.

Action: Watch three things over the next two cycles: whether any entry appears on the debarment list, whether cloud or digital infrastructure is added to the named critical sectors, and whether the European preference chapter survives into the adopted EU regulation ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026). The third matters most, because it will settle whether a Government Procurement Agreement party can lawfully prefer on origin, which is currently the strongest argument that Britain cannot.

MONITOR

Draws on Theme 4

Scenario Matrix

Two uncertainties shape the next four years. The first is whether Britain acquires any instrument that states a position on supplier dependence, or continues to leave it to individual buyers. The second is whether the United States behaves in ways that force the question, through export control, delivery or terms. The second is not in British hands. The first is entirely.

US BEHAVIOUR: STEADY AND PREDICTABLE → DISRUPTIVE ENOUGH TO FORCE THE QUESTION

The comfortable default

Nothing forces the issue.

Agreements renew, the exemption works well enough for most trade, and the debarment list stays empty ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025).

Dependence deepens quietly because every individual decision is defensible and nothing aggregates them. This is the current path.

Early indicators: Successor agreement awarded without published exit or concentration terms; no dependency measure commissioned; critical sector list unchanged.

Improvising under pressure

A licence refusal, a delivery slip or a tariff move forces a response. Britain has no prepared instrument for. Decisions get made quickly, department by department, under the same discretion that produced the position. The Swiss example shows what a prepared buyer does ([the Swiss defence department](#), May 2026); improvisation is what an unprepared one does.

Early indicators: An export licence or delivery dispute becomes public; departments diverge in their responses; emergency use of the national security exemption ([PPN 025](#), Jun 2026).

Deliberate dependence

Britain publishes a measure and a threshold and concludes, on the evidence, that substantial American supply is the right answer. Dependence is unchanged and its status is transformed, because it has been argued for, costed and signed. This is the outcome the briefing is arguing for, and it is not the same as reducing dependence.

STEADY US, STATED POSITION

dependency assessment covering defence and digital; an explicit ministerial statement of acceptable concentration; awards carrying reported measures.

Hedged and ready

The hedge the Lords committee recommended exists in instruments rather than in prose ([the House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee](#), Apr 2026), so disruption meets a prepared response: known alternatives, contract terms that permit substitution, and a position on design authority ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025).

Expensive to build and only visible in

DISRUPTIVE US, STATED POSITION

Early indicators: Design authority language appears in a UK contract; alternative suppliers qualified in advance; cloud added to the critical sectors.

What We Are Not Planning For

OUT OF SCOPE THIS CYCLE

A British Buy European or Buy British rule

No instrument in this evidence base proposes one, and the statutory non-discrimination duty owed to treaty state suppliers would have to be addressed first ([Procurement Act guidance](#), Sep 2024). The briefing examines whether Britain has a position on dependence, which is a prior and different question from whether it should prefer a bloc.

↺ **Reinstated if** the European preference chapter is adopted in the EU regulation ([COM\(2026\) 590](#), Sep 2026) and the UK publishes any assessment of whether equivalent design is open to it.

OUT OF SCOPE THIS CYCLE

The AUKUS submarine programme

The submarine pillar is a multi-decade capability programme with its own governance and its own parliamentary scrutiny, and treating it as an instance of procurement dependence would obscure both. This cycle uses the export-control exemption and the combat air programme, where the instruments are visible and dated.

↺ **Reinstated if** a scrutiny body publishes findings on submarine programme supply dependence comparable to the F-35 work ([the Public Accounts Committee](#), Oct 2025).

DELIBERATELY NOT MODELLED

A rupture in the relationship

Scenarios in which the United States withdraws cooperation wholesale are not modelled. Nothing in the evidence supports them, the Lords committee found a transactional relationship rather than a failing one ([the House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee](#), Apr 2026), and modelling a rupture would crowd out the more likely and more actionable case, which is friction at the margins of an arrangement Britain cannot adjust.

↺ **Reinstated if** a documented refusal of a capability transfer to the UK, or suspension of an existing programme obligation.

Questions For The Next Strategy Meeting

Five questions this cycle's evidence should put on the agenda.

- 01 What proportion of UK defence and digital procurement flows to suppliers ultimately controlled from the United States, and if nobody can answer that, who should be asked to ([MOD official statistics](#), Sep 2025)?
- 02 The powers of exclusion and debarment have been live since February 2025 and the published list is empty ([the National Security Unit for Procurement](#), Mar 2025). Is that a fact about suppliers or a fact about the lever?
- 03 The successor cloud agreement is a 14 billion pound buying channel replacing three others ([the tender notice](#), Oct 2025). What conditions attach at award, and is there any later moment at which they could be attached instead?
- 04 Europe has written design authority free of third-country restriction into binding law ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025). What would the equivalent British clause say, and what would it cost us in supplier choice?

05 The June policy note names shipbuilding, steel, artificial intelligence and energy infrastructure as critical sectors (PPN 025, Jun 2026). On what basis was the cloud estate that carries most government data left out?

Source Confidence Register

This briefing draws on 34 verified sources under a declared twelve-month window. 22 were published inside it. 12 sit outside it and are carried as structural anchors, which on this subject means standing law, standing regulatory schemes and long-run baselines rather than recent reporting; each is named as an anchor in the record. 0 carry no publication date anywhere on the page and are recorded as undated rather than given an inferred one. 6 are in a language other than English and were read in the original.

Source tiers: **Tier 1**, governments, parliaments, regulators, courts and intergovernmental bodies. **Tier 2**, national audit offices, think-tanks, academic institutes and major professional firms. **Tier 3**, quality journalism and specialist trade press. **Tier 4**, vendor and practitioner sources, used only as directional corroboration. This cycle uses no Tier 4 source.

Theme 1: Britain has already chosen, and did not call it a choice

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
House of Commons Library	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The Library describes the UK-US Economic Prosperity Deal announced on 8 May 2025 as a legally non-binding agreement seeking to lessen the impact of US tariffs, whose terms have been only partially implemented. It records a 10% baseline tariff, a 10% rate on up to 100,000 UK-made cars a year, pharmaceuticals tariff-free from 1 December 2025, and a temporary metals exemption retaining the 25% tariff and contingent on the progress of negotiations.
Hansard, House of Commons	Tier 1	Dec 2025	The Paymaster General told the House that he chose not to sign up to participate in the SAFE fund because it did not represent value for money, in an exchange in which the Opposition criticised both that decision and the wider agreement.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Sénat, Commission des affaires étrangères, de la défense et des forces armées (in French)	Tier 1	Dec 2025	The rapporteurs record, citing SIPRI for 2020 to 2024, that the United States supplied 64% of the arms imported by European NATO member states, and describe SAFE as a 150 billion euro loan instrument whose eligibility rule requires at least 65% of the estimated value of components to come from eligible European sources, leaving a 35% ceiling for non-European content.
UK Parliament, Written Statements, Cabinet Office	Tier 1	Dec 2025	The Paymaster General records that the Security and Defence Partnership unlocked the possibility of enhanced UK participation in the Security Action for Europe instrument, that formal negotiations began in good faith and ended without agreement, and that UK industry retains access to SAFE under standard third country terms, able to provide up to 35% of the content of a SAFE contract.
Ministry of Defence (Official Statistics)	Tier 1	Sep 2025	Payments through Foreign Military Sales agreements with the US Government totalled 623 million pounds in 2024-25, and payments to the United States of 1,202 million pounds to the US Government and 372 million pounds to the US Treasury are recorded as predominantly for F-35 and Trident through international collaborative agreements.
Ministry of Defence (Command Paper CP 1388)	Tier 1	Sep 2025	The Strategy reserves full or majority UK-based industrial capability for a narrow set of strategic imperatives including the nuclear deterrent, submarines and cryptography, accepts allied supply for the rest, and promises an offset policy so that investment in overseas suppliers returns value to the British economy. It names 2.5 billion pounds more MOD spending with small and medium enterprises by May 2028 and over 2 billion pounds of research and development in 2026-27.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Ministry of Defence	Tier 1	Jun 2025	The Review states that with the United States clear that the security of Europe is no longer its primary international focus, the UK and European allies must step up, and then sets NATO First as its defining principle, qualified by NATO First not meaning NATO only.
Cabinet Office and the European Union (joint text)	Tier 1	May 2025	The Partnership commits the two sides to regular exchanges on defence readiness and defence industry, leaves an administrative arrangement with the European Defence Agency to be explored, confines PESCO involvement to military mobility, and defers mutual involvement in defence initiatives to later negotiation.

Theme 2: The dependency that is load bearing was bought through frameworks

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology	Tier 1	Aug 2026	UK spending on cloud has grown by nearly 30% a year since 2020, reaching 10.5 billion pounds in 2024, and Amazon Web Services and Microsoft together hold 60% to 80% of the UK cloud market. The US CLOUD Act allows the US Government to access data held by US companies outside the US for investigations into serious crime, and providers must comply with US law once a demand is properly made.
Government Digital Service and Government Commercial Agency	Tier 1	Jul 2026	Government sets five national-scale cloud challenges to industry, stating that single fully-featured regions in-country are not sufficient, that those seeking to stay within UK jurisdiction and be multi-region resilient should have access to at least two fully-featured regions, that public cloud as implemented today struggles to defend against the most capable adversaries, and that approaches must avoid creating structural lock-in or barriers to entry for British suppliers.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Competition and Markets Authority	Tier 1	Mar 2026	The CMA Board decided to launch a strategic market status investigation into Microsoft's business software ecosystem from May 2026 and not to open one into Amazon Web Services, accepting instead actions offered by both firms on cloud egress fees and interoperability, with progress to be reviewed in six months.
House of Commons Library	Tier 1	Mar 2026	Microsoft, Amazon, Google and other US-based companies could in principle be compelled to provide the US Government with access to UK customers' data held in their UK data centres. The Library records at least 14 billion pounds a year of government spend on digital programmes and technology, that procurement approaches favour large suppliers, and a December 2025 ministerial answer accepting that government recognises its dependence on a small number of key suppliers.
Crown Commercial Service, Find a Tender Service	Tier 1	Oct 2025	The tender notice gives a total framework value of 14 billion pounds excluding value added tax, and states that G-Cloud 15 is the proposed replacement for G-Cloud 14, G-Cloud 14 Lot 4 and Cloud Compute 2.
Committee of Public Accounts, House of Commons	Tier 1	Jun 2025	The Committee finds government's approach to buying cloud fragmented and not right, records at least 14 billion pounds of annual spend with technology suppliers, and reports that the Government Commercial Function had only 15 people dedicated to the full-time management of the 19 largest technology suppliers. It notes switching cloud providers is very expensive, complex and disruptive.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
National Audit Office	Tier 2	Jan 2025	At least 14 billion pounds is spent annually on government digital procurement, of which 9 billion pounds ran through Crown Commercial Service frameworks in 2022-23, and three very large multinational providers hold a combined global market share of over 60% of cloud services. The audit office concludes government has not aligned responsibilities, skills and resources to lead digital procurement.
Computer Weekly	Tier 3	Mar 2026	Amazon Web Services was awarded a ten-year contract worth 473 million pounds with HM Revenue and Customs despite being the only bidder, covering migration of three datacentres to cloud. A former Cabinet Office IT strategy director is quoted questioning whether a procurement ending with a single bidder was ever truly open.
DatacenterDynamics	Tier 3	Jul 2025	The G-Cloud 14 framework was extended by six months and 1.65 billion pounds, 650 million pounds across lots one to three and a further 1 billion pounds for lot four, moving the end date from April 2026 to October 2026 against an original value of 7.5 billion pounds. In December 2024 the Crown Commercial Service increased its cloud hosting deal with Amazon Web Services by 89% mid-contract.

Theme 3: Reliability is becoming a specification rather than a diplomatic question

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Haut-commissariat à la Stratégie et au Plan (in French)	Tier 1	Jun 2026	The note states that under the extraterritorial reach of ITAR European states can find themselves prevented from exporting equipment that incorporates an American component, that a single controlled component can contaminate an entire system, and that the United States can then impose restrictions for commercial as well as strategic reasons. It reports that only 52% of European NATO contracts between February 2022 and September 2024 concerned European systems.
Eidgenössisches Departement für Verteidigung, Bevölkerungsschutz und Sport (in German)	Tier 1	May 2026	Switzerland has been told to expect a Patriot delivery delay of five to seven years, against a US estimate of four to five years given in February 2025, and is maintaining its suspension of payments to the US Government. Responses were sought by the end of May 2026 from five further suppliers offering systems from Germany, France, Israel and South Korea, preferably with European production.
House of Lords International Relations and Defence Committee	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The Committee finds that the UK relies on the United States for conventional, space and nuclear capabilities and typically operates militarily only with US support, including for the missiles that deliver nuclear payloads and for position, navigation and timing. It recommends a twin-track approach, engaging with the United States on shared interests and existing programmes while hedging against US volatility through increased sovereign capability and cooperation with European allies.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
US Department of State, Federal Register	Tier 1	Dec 2025	The final rule permits licence-free export, reexport, retransfer and brokering among authorised users in Australia, the UK and the US, and the Department assesses that approximately 18% of licensing requests would not be eligible under the exemption because of the Excluded Technologies List. Over 700 entities from Australia and the United Kingdom have become authorised users.
Committee of Public Accounts, House of Commons	Tier 1	Oct 2025	The Committee records that the UK has a formal policy requirement to be able to use the F-35 at any time or place of its choosing, known as freedom of action, while finding that the United States orders approximately 80% of all aircraft, that weapons integration depends on Block 4 software which has not been fully defined or timetabled and which the UK cannot directly influence, and that nuclear handling standards are set by the United States. The whole-life cost estimate more than tripled to almost 57 billion pounds, against a National Audit Office estimate of 71 billion.
US Government Accountability Office	Tier 1	Sep 2025	Block 4 costs have exceeded original estimates by over 6 billion dollars with completion delayed at least five years, and the programme plans to reduce the scope of Block 4. Technology Refresh 3, a 1.9 billion dollar hardware and software suite critical to Block 4, drove late deliveries, with all 110 aircraft delivered in 2024 arriving an average of 238 days late against 61 days late in 2023.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Council of the European Union, Official Journal	Tier 1	May 2025	Article 16(10) provides that the cost of components originating outside the Union, the European Economic Area member states of the European Free Trade Association and Ukraine shall not be higher than 35% of the estimated cost of the components of the end product. Article 16(11) requires contractors to have the ability to decide, without restrictions imposed by third countries or third-country entities, on the definition, adaptation and evolution of the design of the product procured, including the legal authority to substitute or remove components subject to such restrictions.
United States Studies Centre, University of Sydney	Tier 2	Aug 2024	The authors assess that the reforms would exempt between 70% and 80% of trilateral defence trade from licensing requirements, but that the excluded technologies lists produce a defence free trade zone that is AUKUS by country and not by technology, so many AUKUS-related technologies could be excluded from the framework intended to share them.

Theme 4: Europe legislates sovereignty, Britain leaves it to the buyer

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
European Commission	Tier 1	Sep 2026	The proposal would replace the three 2014 procurement directives with a single Regulation and introduces a dedicated chapter on European Preference, built on defined covered economic operators and covered goods, services or works whose coverage the Commission would set by delegated act, with public buyers given discretion to apply preference requirements. It states repeatedly that the mechanism operates within the World Trade Organization Government Procurement Agreement and the EU's trade agreements, whose parties are treated as covered.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Cabinet Office	Tier 1	Jun 2026	The notice tells in-scope organisations to engage early with a sector lead and that they may deploy the national security exemption in the Procurement Act 2023 where appropriate and justified. It applies mandatorily only to central government departments, their executive agencies and non-departmental public bodies, and names four critical sectors: shipbuilding, steel, artificial intelligence and energy infrastructure.
European Commission, DG CONNECT	Tier 1	Jun 2026	The Act sets out an EU cloud sovereignty framework with four assurance levels, from data processed and stored in the Union at level one, through demonstrated independence from third countries at level two, to providers owned and controlled from the EU at level three and full control of the software supply chain with no third-country interference at level four. It also proposes a common procurement framework for public administrations and a target of at least tripling EU data centre capacity within five to seven years.
Direction des affaires juridiques, Ministère de l'Économie et des Finances (<i>in French</i>)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	A decree of 14 April 2026 requires that where state administrations, listed operators and six designated public interest groupings process particularly sensitive data on a private cloud service, that service must hold the national cyber security agency's qualification or an equivalent European certification, and must protect against access by third-country public authorities not authorised under European or member state law. Derogations for pre-existing projects run to a maximum of eighteen months from the availability of a compliant offer.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Deutscher Bundestag (in German)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The Federal Government reports 8,756 openDesk licences currently held across the federal administration, of which 8,475 are in productive use, against 7,916 at the end of 2025. Of 577 software development contracts awarded across federal ministries in 2025, 109 were explicitly commissioned as open source projects, of which only 42 were published openly.
Direction interministérielle du numérique (in French)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	Every ministry and its operators must formalise a plan to reduce extra-European digital dependencies by autumn 2026, covering workstations, collaborative tools, antivirus, artificial intelligence, databases, virtualisation and network equipment. The national health insurance body is migrating 80,000 staff to interministerial tools, and the health data platform is to move to a trusted solution by the end of 2026.
Cabinet Office	Tier 1	Mar 2025	The unit supports Ministers in assessing suppliers on national security grounds under the Procurement Act 2023, which commenced on 24 February 2025, and oversees exclusion from a specific procurement, termination of a contract and debarment from public contracts. Exclusion on national security grounds requires ministerial agreement, and the published debarment list remains blank.
Cabinet Office	Tier 1	Feb 2025	The statutory statement requires contracting authorities to have regard to it under section 13 of the Procurement Act 2023. Its only treatment of security is a passage on mitigating supply chain and national security risks through controls such as the Cyber Essentials standard and the Government Security Function's supply chain guidance. It refers to putting UK firms in the best possible position to compete, and contains no supplier origin requirement.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Llywodraeth Cymru, Welsh Government	Tier 1	Sep 2024	Under section 89 of the Procurement Act 2023 a treaty state supplier is one entitled to the benefits of an international agreement specified in Schedule 9, and section 90 provides that contracting authorities may not treat such a supplier less favourably than a UK supplier because of its association with its treaty state. Authorities may exclude non-treaty state suppliers from competitive tendering, and below-threshold contracts fall outside the non-discrimination duty.

Claim-fidelity self-disclosure

This appendix records where the evidence base is thinner than a source count suggests, and what was done about it.

Four themes, where the format carries five or six. The analyst commissioning this cycle asked for four. The structure audit flags that as a deviation rather than a pass, and no fifth theme was invented to satisfy the format.

A minister's sentence is summarised rather than quoted, and here it is. The clearest statement of why the UK left the European instrument is the Paymaster General's, and as printed in Hansard it contains two em-dashes, which this house's orthography rule forbids. Altering a quotation to satisfy a formatting rule is not permitted, so the body summarises it and the exact wording is recorded in the source notes ([Hansard](#), Dec 2025). Separately, the widely reported characterisation of the EU's terms as extortionate belongs to the Opposition spokesman in that exchange and not to the minister, and is not used here.

Two figures rest on trade press because the official records could not be retrieved. The single-bidder award value and the mid-contract hosting uplift ([Computer Weekly](#), Mar 2026) ([DatacenterDynamics](#), Jul 2025) are reported by specialist publications. The underlying tender and modification notices exist, but the Find a Tender service returned repeated errors and a mirror refused the request, so those records are not verified here and their URLs are deliberately not cited. Both figures are carried as trade reporting, and anyone relying on them should pull the notices directly.

One central text is summarised rather than quoted, deliberately. The European regulation's design authority provision is the analytical centre of the third theme. It was read and confirmed in the Official Journal, but only in the PDF: two HTML routes to the same instrument returned unrelated documents. A quotation taken from the PDF would be exempted by the systemic override for binary files rather than actually checked by the provenance gate, so the provision is reproduced almost in full in the source record and paraphrased in the body instead ([Regulation \(EU\) 2025/1106](#), May 2025).

Absences are used as evidence three times, and each was checked. The Security and Defence Partnership contains no procurement or industrial language ([the Security and Defence Partnership](#), May 2025), the Strategic Defence Review does not mention the European instrument ([the Strategic Defence Review](#), Jun 2025), and the procurement policy statement contains no supplier origin requirement ([the National Procurement Policy Statement](#), Feb 2025). Each of those is a verified negative from a read of the document, not an inference from a summary. An absence is weaker evidence than a statement, and the body says so where it relies on one.

Twelve of the thirty-four sources sit outside the twelve-month window. They are carried as structural anchors and each is named as one in the register. On this subject that category is doing real work, because the instruments that govern the question are standing law, standing statements and multi-year programmes rather than recent reporting. Two were reclassified as anchors during the audit, the American audit office's annual programme review and the standing guidance on the procurement security unit, both of which are recurring or permanent rather than reports of an event.

The audience is named, and the framing was checked with the commissioning analyst. This cycle is written for a policy adviser rather than for a supplier, which determines why it examines instruments and levers and does not discuss competitive positioning. Lockhouse Systems Limited was incorporated on 8 October 2025; nothing about the company's own commercial position is used, claimed or implied anywhere in this briefing.

Quotation. Four sources are quoted verbatim, one of them in German and one in French. Each non-English span is reproduced in the original, the language is named, and an English rendering follows. All four were checked against their live pages on 18 September 2026 and are stored exactly as published.

This Decision Intelligence briefing is the quarterly synthesis of a Shaping Tomorrow intelligence cycle on the **Lockhouse Systems**. It sits on top of weekly Signal Scans that identify emerging developments and weak signals, and monthly Change Trackers that assess what is materially shifting in momentum. Cycles may also close with Action Triggers, an end-of-cycle synthesis that reads across all four formats and surfaces patterns no single deliverable carries on its own. Continuous intelligence on this topic is available as a Single-Topic or Multi-Topic programme.

Discuss a Tailored Programme

Prepared by Shaping Tomorrow: 18 September 2026